

Seth Byrnes

Game Designer → Systems & Level Design

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

I am a US-based Game Designer with shipped, publicly available work spanning VR, MR, PC and console titles. I have worked professionally in games since 2017. My primary focus areas have been Systems and Level Design, implementation documentation and production support. I have four fully shipped titles and six credits.

SKILLS

Design Skills: Gameplay, Systems, Level, Puzzle, Encounter, Progression, Tutorial, UI / UX, VR / MR Interaction and Economy Design. Balancing, NPC & Enemy Behavior & State Trees and creature design.

Documentation: Technical Design Documentation, Feature Briefs, Wireframes, Gameplay Variables, Tuning Parameters, Playtesting, QA Validation, Production Support, Implementation Review.

Level Design: Blockouts, Grayboxing, Traversal, Narrative pacing, Landmarking, Mission Flow, Combat Spaces,

Engines & Software: Unity, Unreal Engine 4 and 5, Blueprint and Visual Scripting, Other Proprietary Engines (Dromed, Outerra, Unigine, etc), Gaea Terrain Editor, Reaper, Acoustica Mixcraft, Slack, Discord

Production Support: Confluence, Jira, Trello, Google Workspace, Microsoft Office, Figma, Miro, Figma, Excel, Playtest Analysis, Milestone Scoping, Build Review, Task Delegation, Handoff Meetings.

Source Control: Perforce, GIT, TurtleSVN

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Lead Game Designer | April 2023 - October 2025 | Hybrid / Remote

The Deep: Beyond the Reef - Dark Slope

- Fully owned, defined, and iterated the core gameplay loop around exploration, environmental cleanup, puzzle challenges, narrative gating and level design for a shipped VR underwater exploration game released on Meta Quest 3.
- Produced almost all design material across more than 28 documents, including feature briefs with named gameplay variables and tuning parameters, then oversaw and aided implementation and configuration.
- Designed and documented multiple connected levels and their encounters, including the 3 core gameplay hubs, 4 sublevels and a boss finale. Wrote the onboarding path in the first level. Performed in-engine configuration and helped run implementation reviews for all of the above, working directly with art and development teams in-engine.
- Worked directly with the IP holder to keep narrative, puzzle gating, and presentation aligned with story goals.
- Assisted with on-site and remote Quest 3 user testing and translated findings into documentation specifying actionable changes. Solved wayfinding, control, readability, narrative and production issues and saw the title launch.

Game Designer | April 2023 - October 2025 | Remote

DinoHab - Dark Slope

- Owned the primary ecological simulation feature set governing the complete lifecycle of plants and fungi as well as the simulated transfer of nutrients through the ecosystem from preproduction design through implementation, testing, and release for a mixed reality and VR ecosystem-management title released on Meta in 2024.
- Authored a 27-page plant systems design document covering growth states, nutrient logic, ground cover & propagation, environmental needs, dormancy and all implementation requirements.
- Co-developed the game's balancing workbook, programming roughly half of the variables across a shared 9-tab spreadsheet with about 355 formulas for ecosystem, species, and progression configuration.
- Created gated upgrades and currency systems tied to an AI assistant that reinforced engagement and educational cues about the late Cretaceous period.
- Co-authored pet dinosaur interaction mechanics handling relational trust, player interaction and acknowledgement, need satisfaction and leveling, and defined the creature state tree for all player-animal interactions before helping configure the implementation in-engine.

- Designed three progression-driven habitat spaces with herd-management considerations and player-pet interactions including feeding, petting, sleep, and minigame support.
- Supported tutorialization, narrative gating, player tool design, production wireframing, stakeholder review, and milestone planning through production to release.

Game Designer | April 2023 - October 2025 | Remote

Monster Simulator 3000 - Dark Slope

- Owned enemy and hybrid arcade-roguelike encounter systems from preproduction implementation through iteration, testing, final balance and polish for a first-person VR kaiju destruction game focused on replayability, dynamic combat pressure, and urban destruction.
- Authored more than 16 design specifications covering level workflow, encounter design, enemy behavior and taxonomy, world generation, player progression, and final tuning.
- Defined scoring rules, physics behavior, enemy spawn wave logic, player perk tuning, end-of-run stat tracking, and progression feedback to strengthen gameplay.
- Designed city randomization rules covering building height, type, placement, and mirrored starts to keep repeat runs from feeling static.
- Created level briefs designed for replayability and production documentation covering milestones, art requirements, iteration, playtesting and balancing passes.

SELECTED PROJECT CREDITS

Game Designer | September 2021 - April 2023 | Hybrid

Civatlas - Sharp End Studio

- Led design work from concept through Early Access release across systems design, production planning and wireframing, implementation support, UI and audio prototyping, artist reference, and day-to-day feature direction on an isometric city builder title.
- Advanced the project through 40+ game design documents covering topics such as resource and world generation, UI/UX presentation, tutorialization, menus, core construction mechanics, and NPC behavior/task assignment.
- Helped define and refine 12 core NPC and settlement behaviors, including housing, labor assignment, career qualification logic, stockpile behavior, and automation rules.
- Produced and maintained a large live design document throughout production covering world generation & biomes, construction plot systems, NPC life cycles, economics, controls, progression, and production phases.

Level Designer / QA | March 2022 - March 2023 | Remote

Battle Cry of Freedom - Flying Squirrel Entertainment

- Researched historical battles and real-world locations through period photographs and historical material culture to support map planning, environmental authenticity, and landmark selection.
- Produced paper designs, terrain roughouts, level blockouts, terrain iterations, and final layout and balancing polish for multiplayer third-person shooter spaces.
- Considered gamemode-specific flow in a proprietary editor while using external terrain workflow tools to create and refine Gaea splatmaps, grayboxes and final levels.
- Designed paths from spawn to capture points around bottlenecks, gates, destructible spaces, shifting spawn zones, and sightline control.
- Used cover mechanics, elevation & ridgelines, fully destructible structures, and visual anchors to shape mass movement, combat readability, sightlines, and battle rhythm for large mixed server populations of approximately 200 players and bots.
- Built levels around period ballistics, melee combat, vehicles, and siege-minded fortifications grounded in historical references.
- Composed set dressing, performed iteration, and facilitated QA so final maps remained both believable and playable.

Game Designer & Historical Researcher | October 2020 - December 2022 | Hamilton, ON

B-17: Flying Fortress The Bloody 100th - MicroProse Canada

- Built and organized a structured historical reference pipeline of 380+ production-useful items covering Thorpe Abbots Airbase. Assembled briefs and environmental specifications for USAAF operations, crew life, bomber-support mission structure, uniforms, signage, and broad material culture of the Second World War in an effort to completely recreate an airbase circa 1944 for a hardcore bomber simulation revival game.
- Collaborated with museum contacts to find and translate primary-source archival material into usable design, environment, mission and narrative reference specifications.
- Facilitated production of a full airbase layout mockup with targeted reference materials to support scale, placement, define important navigational landmarks and environmental storytelling.
- Researched and documented material used as the basis for crew-management, mission, and progression systems intended to reflect bomber crew strain.
- Worked with programmers and artists to maintain historical accuracy across gameplay elements, environments, and mission planning to define a 25-mission replayable bomber campaign.
- Proposed mission-designer features for player-authored scenarios and performed in-engine tuning work in Unreal and Outerra.
- Supported documentation, research validation, and promotional release content for the game.

User Interface Designer / QA Tester | July 2019 - October 2019 | Hybrid

Dune Sea - Frolic Labs

- Owned the full player-facing UI for the game. Wireframed and produced art for the entire flow across main menu, settings, tutorial, pause, level select, and in-game interfaces.
- Produced UI assets and supporting documentation to guide developers.
- Performed QA testing on the build to identify usability problems, bugs, and friction to ensure the flow-state goals of the game were being met.
- Demonstrated the game publicly at EGLX, supporting booth operation through setup and teardown as well as live presentation guidance and quality.

Junior Game Designer | September 2017 - April 2018 | Oakville / Toronto, ON

Roll Together - Mindwax Games

- Helped design and refine a cooperative installation game concept built for large groups of phone-connected players.
- Designed a fast onboarding, immediately readable core mechanic as well as obstacle timing, and shared puzzle solving interactions for a projected drop-in installation.
- Produced one full obstacle-course level and workshoped two additional levels during development.
- Worked with a small interdisciplinary team to scope, prototype and test designs.
- Contributed level hazard, gate, and interaction designs for public-facing prototype work.
- Tested prototype across multiple devices and supported three public showcases, including EGLX and LevelUP.

Junior Game Designer / QA | January 2017 - May 2017 | Kitchener, ON

First Impact: Rise of a Hero / Onslaught - Red Meat Games

- Designed 4 replayable arena levels with increasing tiers of difficulty and helped structure progression and wave-based escalation.
- Wrote and maintained design documentation in collaboration with senior designers.
- Integrated art and gameplay assets, performed in-engine fixes, and supported feature tuning during development.
- Worked in QA on levels, superpowers, and gameplay flow while reporting and helping resolve issues, and helped mentor a junior programmer.

Quality Assurance Tester | September 2016 - October 2017 | Remote

Half-Rats: Parasomnia - Heath Games LLC

- Playtested the full product and documented bugs and other issues with screenshots, location notes, reproduction steps, and context.
- Identified softlocks and major friction points, then retested fixes after integration.
- Reported issues with balance and progression, visuals and readability, UI, horror events, and general usability.
- Produced gameplay and level reports with suggestions for encounter quality, vibe, and narrative clarity.
- Flagged gameplay and level-layout problems affecting pacing, tension, and overall flow.
- Helped improve moment-to-moment player experience through practical QA feedback and programmer collaboration on weapon and enemy interactions.

Community Level Designer / Server Operator | 2015 - 2018 | Remote

Mount & Blade: With Fire & Sword Community Maps - Independent / Self-Directed

- Designed and iterated 20+ original multiplayer maps and overhauled 50+ community maps.
- Designed contested routes from spawn to capture points around chokepoints, gates, and readable sightlines for Renaissance-era combat.
- Balanced level layouts around weapon ranges, different class movement speeds, weapon ranges, game modes, traffic patterns, and faction matchups.
- Built siege-minded fortresses and defensive spaces using historical references on period architecture and entrenchment.
- Managed and grew an online server community through content production, modded gameplay and community engagement.
- Supported client-side and server-side gameplay modifications tied to live community needs, increasing server traffic by about 50 percent through these supports.

EDUCATION

Sheridan College- Bachelor's Degree, Game and Interactive Media Design | 2014 - 2018

University of Guelph- History | 2013 - 2014